WAVERLEY GATEWAY GUIDE

Connecting International Capital

SLOVAKIA

Europe

Information current as of November 2026

Dialogue | Trust | Partnership

office@lordwaverley.com
www.lordwaverley.com

WHERE AND HOW TO ENTER

KEY INVESTMENT LOCATIONS

Location / Region	Strategic Importance	Priority Sectors
Bratislava	Capital and richest region, bordering Austria and Hungary, with the seat of government, the National Bank of Slovakia and most shared-service and technology centres	Automotive, business services, IT, finance, logistics
Košice and eastern Slovakia	Site of Volvo Cars' new plant, designed to build 250,000 cars a year with large-scale production due in early 2027, creating a new supplier base in the east	Electric vehicles, automotive suppliers, IT, steel
Trnava and Nitra (western Slovakia)	Established automotive corridor close to Bratislava with major carmaker plants and dense supplier networks	Automotive assembly and components, logistics
Žilina and the north-west	Industrial region on the corridor to Czechia and Poland with a strong automotive and engineering base	Automotive, engineering, IT
Jaslovské Bohunice	Existing nuclear site where a new state-owned 1,200 MWe US-designed unit is planned under a January 2026 Slovakia–US intergovernmental agreement	Nuclear energy, engineering, construction services
Central Slovakia (Banská Bystrica region)	Area where SARIO reports growing investor interest, with lower costs and available labour	Manufacturing, wood and forestry, tourism

INVESTOR ENTRY ROUTES

- SARIO, the Slovak Investment and Trade Development Agency, provides free investor facilitation, site selection and aftercare; it concluded 33 projects worth about €439 million in 2025 and has a pipeline of 69 projects worth over €4.9 billion
- State investment aid under EU state-aid rules, including grants and tax relief for projects such as manufacturing, technology centres and shared-service centres, arranged through the Ministry of Economy and SARIO
- Corporate income tax in three tiers: 10% for revenue up to €100,000, 21% up to €5 million and 24% above €5 million; standard VAT is 23%
- Euro-area membership since 2009: the euro is the national currency, with free movement of capital and profit repatriation under EU rules

- EU single-market and Schengen membership, giving tariff-free access to EU markets and passport-free movement across most of Europe
- Government-backed industrial parks and strategic investment sites, including the Volvo site near Košice, offering serviced land for large manufacturing projects
- EU co-financing through the Recovery and Resilience Plan and cohesion programmes for transport, energy, digital and innovation projects

MARKET-ENTRY OBSERVATION

Slovakia offers investors a euro-area manufacturing base at the heart of Central Europe, with deep automotive expertise and a skilled industrial workforce. GDP grew 0.8% in 2025 and 0.8% year-on-year in the second quarter of 2026, when exports rose 3.0% and the trade surplus exceeded €0.5 billion, its highest since early 2024. The investment pipeline is substantial: SARIO concluded 33 projects worth about €439 million in 2025, with 69 more worth over €4.9 billion in progress, and Volvo Cars' Košice plant, designed for 250,000 cars a year, is due to reach large-scale production in early 2027. In January 2026 Slovakia and the United States signed an intergovernmental agreement for a new 1,200 MWe nuclear unit at Bohunice, backed by export-credit cooperation between the two countries' Eximbanks.

Slovakia's main structural challenge is restoring its public finances while keeping growth and investment on track. The general government deficit was 4.5% of GDP in 2025, is expected at 4.37% in 2026, and the draft 2027 budget targets 4.94%, while public debt rose to 61.4% of GDP in 2025. Consumer price inflation was 3.1% in September 2026, and the ECB raised its deposit rate to 2.50% in September 2026, holding it there on 29 October, as energy prices lifted euro-area inflation. The government has introduced consolidation measures, including the 24% corporate tax band and a 23% VAT rate, and Moody's affirmed Slovakia's A3 rating with a stable outlook in June 2026. Euro membership, EU funding and a strong export sector provide resilience, and new automotive and energy projects create sustained opportunities for suppliers and investors.

INVESTOR RISK & MARKET ACCESS

KEY ENTRY BARRIERS

Issue	Potential Impact	Possible Mitigation
Fiscal deficit and rising debt	The deficit was 4.5% of GDP in 2025 and the 2027 budget targets 4.94%, with debt at 61.4% of GDP	Consolidation measures, euro membership and an A3 rating anchor financing; model further tax changes into business plans
Tax changes	Recent consolidation raised VAT to 23% and introduced a 24% corporate tax rate for companies with revenue above €5 million	Take local tax advice early and assess eligibility for state investment aid and tax relief
Rule of law and EU relations	The European Parliament in May 2026 asked the Commission to assess rule-of-law concerns; the government says EU and recovery-plan payments continue	EU law and courts provide recourse; structure EU-funded projects with strong compliance and monitor Commission decisions
Dependence on the automotive sector	A large share of industry and exports is tied to car production, exposing growth to European demand and trade tensions	Diversify into electric-vehicle supply chains, technology centres, energy and business services, where SARIO reports growing interest
Inflation and energy costs	Inflation was 3.1% in September 2026, and higher energy prices are lifting costs across the euro area	Use long-term energy contracts and build wage and energy scenarios into plans; the 2027 budget includes €250 million for energy-price support
Labour availability	Skilled labour is tight in the western automotive corridor	Consider central and eastern regions, partner with universities and use EU-funded training
Regional security	Slovakia borders Ukraine, which remains at war with Russia	As an EU and NATO member Slovakia benefits from collective security; include routine contingency planning for eastern operations

INVESTOR RISK NOTE

Slovakia's risk profile is that of an established EU, euro-area and NATO member with an open, export-led economy and an A3 credit rating affirmed by Moody's in June 2026. The main issues for investors are fiscal: the deficit remains above 4% of GDP and debt passed 60% of GDP in 2025, so further tax and spending measures are likely. Relations with EU institutions also merit monitoring after the European Parliament's May 2026 resolution on the rule of law, although the government reports that EU and recovery-plan funds continue to flow. Slovakia is not on the FATF list of jurisdictions under increased monitoring. These factors are manageable within the EU legal framework, and the euro removes currency risk for investors from the euro area.

MARKET ACCESS

As an EU member, Slovakia gives investors tariff-free access to the EU single market of some 450 million people and to all the EU's free trade agreements, with WTO membership and the EU's common trade policy governing trade with third countries. Euro-area membership since 2009 removes exchange-rate costs for trade with its main partners, and Schengen membership allows passport-free movement to neighbouring Czechia, Austria, Hungary and Poland. Germany and its Central European neighbours are its main markets, and Slovakia's motorway and rail links, the Danube port of Bratislava and the broad-gauge rail terminal near Košice connect it with Western Europe and markets to the east. Exports rose 3.0% year-on-year in the second quarter of 2026.

WHO SHOULD THE INVESTOR MEET?

INSTITUTIONAL LANDSCAPE

Actor	Why It Matters	Waverley Engagement Angle
Office of the Government (Prime Minister Robert Fico)	Sets economic, fiscal and energy policy, and led the January 2026 nuclear agreement with the United States	Primary reference point for strategic projects and government priorities
SARIO (Slovak Investment and Trade Development Agency)	National investment and export promotion agency under the Ministry of Economy, with 69 projects worth over €4.9 billion in its pipeline	Standard first point of contact for market entry, sites and incentives
National Bank of Slovakia (NBS)	Member of the Eurosystem; its governor sits on the ECB Governing Council and it supervises banks and financial markets	Relevant for banking, payments and financial-sector licensing
Ministry of Finance (Minister Ladislav Kamenický)	Leads the budget, tax policy and fiscal consolidation	Key counterpart on tax and public-finance matters
Ministry of Economy	Oversees industrial policy, state investment aid, energy policy and SARIO	Relevant for incentives, energy and manufacturing investment
Slovenské elektrárne and the state nuclear programme	Slovenské elektrárne operates the Bohunice units; the new unit there is planned as a fully state-owned project	Counterpart for suppliers and partners in the nuclear and power sector
Eximbanka SR	State export-credit agency that signed a nuclear-financing cooperation agreement with the US Export-Import Bank in January 2026	Useful for export finance and project co-financing

CURRENT INTERNATIONAL BUSINESS CHANNELS

The American Chamber of Commerce in Slovakia, the British Chamber of Commerce in Slovakia, the Slovak-German Chamber of Industry and Commerce and the Slovak Chamber of Commerce and Industry are the main business associations, with sector committees and regular dialogue with government. SARIO runs investor events and business missions, including the Slovak Industry Vision Day forum, and supports supplier matchmaking with large investors such as Volvo. The Automotive Industry Association of the Slovak Republic represents the country's leading sector. The European Investment Bank, the EBRD and EU programmes managed by national ministries offer co-financing for qualifying projects, and embassies of major EU partners and the United States maintain commercial sections that are a useful source of introductions.

INVESTOR PROFILE BEST SUITED

Slovakia suits investors seeking an industrial base inside the euro area: automotive and electric-vehicle suppliers serving Volvo in Košice and established carmakers in the west; engineering and energy companies targeting the new Bohunice nuclear unit and grid investment; technology and shared-service centres drawing on Bratislava and Košice talent; and logistics investors using Slovakia's position between Western Europe, Central Europe and Ukraine. Investors should plan for further fiscal measures and take tax advice on the tiered corporate tax regime.

FROM INTELLIGENCE TO ENGAGEMENT

STEP 1: Engage SARIO and test eligibility for investment aid
Open direct dialogue with SARIO on sites, state investment aid and tax relief, and on supplier opportunities linked to major investors.

STEP 2: Shortlist locations by labour and supplier access
Compare the western automotive corridor with Košice and central Slovakia, where labour is more available and Volvo is building a new supplier base.

STEP 3: Map EU and export-credit funding
Identify Recovery Plan and cohesion programmes, and Eximbanka or export-credit support, that can co-finance project components.

STEP 4: Plan for fiscal and tax developments
Track the 2027 budget and any further consolidation measures, and take advice on the 21% and 24% corporate tax bands and VAT.

STEP 5: Position for energy and nuclear opportunities
Follow the Bohunice new-build programme and build relationships with state energy counterparts and US-led supply chains.